

07__passed__spotpay.json

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{
  "company_name": "SpotPay",
  "founded_year": 2025,
  "headquarters": "San Francisco, CA",
  "founders": [
    {
      "name": "Zsika Phillip-Baptiste",
      "role": "Co-founder & CEO",
      "background": "Stanford MBA candidate; former Product Manager at Google and Software Engineer at YouTube; previously founded Astros AI."
    },
    {
      "name": "Thomas Cesare-Herriau",
      "role": "Co-founder & CTO",
      "background": "Software engineer with deep expertise in full-stack development and high-scale financial infrastructure."
    }
  ],
  "founding_team": {
    "key_expertise": "The team leverages a mix of Big Tech product experience (Google/YouTube) and early-stage startup agility, focused on bridging traditional finance with blockchain rails.",
    "specialization": "Specialists in stablecoin liquidity, mobile UX, and cross-border regulatory compliance."
  },
  "traction": {
    "funding": {
      "total_funding": "$500,000",
      "latest_round": "Y Combinator Winter 2026 Batch ($450k - $500k standard deal)",
      "lead_investors": "Y Combinator",
      "participating_investors": [
        "Alliance (Web3 Accelerator)",
        "F4 Fund"
      ]
    }
  },
  "business_metrics": [
    "Reported 43% week-over-week growth in Total Payment Volume (TPV) during early 2026.",
    "Launched the 'Calypso Card,' a physical global spending card tied to stablecoin balances.",
    "Growing presence in emerging market corridors, specifically the Latin American and Caribbean regions."
  ],
  "problem_statement": {
    "core_issue": "Cross-border finance is fundamentally broken for individuals and small businesses in emerging markets.",
    "barriers": [
      "The 'SWIFT' Tax: Traditional transfers take 3–5 days and lose 5–7% in hidden FX fees and intermediary bank charges.",
      "Financial Exclusion: High minimum balances and strict documentation requirements keep million
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s 'unbanked' or 'underbanked' globally.",

"Currency Volatility: Users in hyper-inflationary environments lack easy, cheap access to stable-value assets like the US Dollar."

]

},

"solution": {

"primary_product": "Borderless Neobank & Digital Wallet",

"key_features": [

"Stablecoin Rails: Uses blockchain and USDC/USDT to settle international transfers in under 3 minutes.",

"QR-Based Local Payments: Enables users to pay local merchants directly from their digital wallet via integrated QR codes.",

"AI-Powered Insights: An embedded agent that analyzes spending patterns to suggest automated savings and yield-bearing opportunities.",

"Yield-on-Store: Allows users to earn interest on their digital dollar balances through audited DeFi protocols."

],

"value_proposition": "Providing a 'global bank account in your pocket' that bypasses the friction of local legacy banking for the next billion users."

},

"hypothetical_investment_rejection_reasoning": {

"red_ocean_competition": "The space is incredibly crowded with heavily-capitalized incumbents like Wise, Revolut, and Airwallex. While SpotPay has early traction, they lack a structural 'moat' to prevent these giants from simply toggling on stablecoin features for their existing millions of users.",

"neobank_commoditization": "As financial infrastructure platforms (like Stripe or Adyen) move closer to the metal, the value of a standalone 'neobank' brand is declining. We believe value is shifting to the underlying infrastructure layers rather than the consumer-facing wallet.",

"regulatory_tail_risk": "Operating a stablecoin-native bank in emerging markets is a legal minefield. A single regulatory crackdown on 'unlicensed' money transmission or stablecoin custody in a key market like Mexico or Brazil could wipe out their primary growth engine.",

"margin_erosion": "The 'race to zero' on cross-border fees makes it difficult to build a high-margin business. Unless SpotPay can successfully cross-sell high-margin credit products—which introduces significant balance-sheet risk—the unit economics remain challenging at scale.",

"customer_acquisition_costs": "Acquiring users in the LatAm/Caribbean region is notoriously expensive and operationally intensive. We are concerned that their 43% WoW growth is a 'honeymoon' phase that will normalize into a high-CAC, low-LTV (Life Time Value) trap."

}

}